

the workload of its officers and improved their efficiency and focus on areas such as timely settlement of claims.

SIMPLIFYING TRANSFERS

Many complaints pertain to transfer requests from members employed before 2017 who have just a member ID but no UAN or haven't linked their UAN to Aadhaar.

"They only come to us when they actually need the money. At that time, because our data is distinct and maintained in separate databases, there is a huge effort for the claimant to get the account transferred from one office to another. And they are able to withdraw funds only when they are accumulated in one office," says

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The EPFO is looking to address this. "Just like we did for joint declarations, we are going to fully automate all transfers after 2017. If a member joined after 2017, we are going to suo moto transfer all the amount to the latest employment," he says.

Simultaneously, the EPFO is working to consolidate its 123 databases into a single database under the CITES 2.01 project. Once this is done, it expects 60-70% of all transfers to be automatic.

"For the rest, we will come out with a large campaign to educate members about how to go about this process and make sure they do it well in advance, rather than waiting till when they need a housing loan or something," says the CPFC.

NEW REFORMS UNDERWAY

▶ The EPFO is planning to automate transfers for members who have joined after 2017

▶ It is also working on consolidating its 123 databases, which will help 60-70% transfer cases under the CITES project

▶ It plans to start a campaign for members with pre-2017 accounts without UAN or Aadhaar linkage

▶ It is also working to boost compliance of member establishments to widen coverage of workers

HOW THE EPFO WORKS

▶ All establishments with 20 workers or more have to become members of the EPFO

▶ Workers in these establishments with a monthly basic salary up to ₹15,000 have to be enrolled as members

▶ Employers and employees have to contribute 12% each of the basic salary

▶ Of the employer's contribution, 8.33% is diverted to the Employees' Pension Scheme, 1995, and 3.67% goes into the EPF

▶ The full contribution from the employee's salary goes to the EPF

In fact, the CITES 2.01 project is in the final stages of testing and is likely to be rolled out in a few months. The revamped Electronic Challan-cum-Return and user management modules have already been launched; three more modules for pension, claims processing and annual accounts are under testing.

EXPANDING COVERAGE

Changing the wage cap from the current ₹15,000 a month and threshold to 20 workers per establishment for greater coverage under the EPFO is a policy decision, Krishnamurthi says, but the retirement fund manager is taking other measures to improve compliance.

On its Foundation Day on November 1, Mandaviya launched the Employees' Enrolment Scheme 2025 that aims to encourage employers to voluntarily declare and enrol eligible employees. The scheme provides that employers will not be required to remit the employee's share of contribution if not deducted earlier, and only a nominal penal charge of ₹100 will apply along with interest on delayed PF contributions.

Simultaneously, the EPFO is identifying establishments that have filed their draft ECR, which is an online monthly return to pay PF contributions, but are not remitting them actually. Initially, it selected about 4,000 establishments and sent them an SMS that they have not completed the filing process.